Introduction

More than six decades of freedom have quadrupled the population of India and transformed its democracy from the impoverished state of post–British India's Raj into the world's newest Asian superpower. India's military power and economy now approach those of the United States of America and China. The same six decades have diminished Pakistan from its promising origins as the world's largest Muslim state into an almost failed fragment of itself, more than half of its population having broken away to become independent Bangladesh in 1971. The only way in which India and Pakistan have remained virtually unchanged after sixty-three years is in their persistent conflict over the state of Jammu and Kashmir, the final tragic legacy of British India's 1947 partition, which followed the "shameful flight" of Great Britain's armed forces from India.[1] More than ten million terrified Hindus, Muslims, and Sikhs fled their ancestral homes that August, one million of whom died before reaching safe havens.

This book is the fruit of my own sixty years of preoccupation with India and Pakistan and their history. My first visit to India, in February 1948, brought me to Bombay on the day Mahatma Gandhi's ashes were immersed in the waters of Back Bay. I had never seen so many people: millions of silent mourners all dressed in white, waiting patiently from the dock's western Gateway to India to the crowded heart of that great city, surrounding the Taj Mahal Hotel, filling Victoria Station, Crawford Market, and Chaupati Beach, where a white ship bearing an urn with part of the Mahatma's ashes waited to sail out into the bay. I was shocked to learn that Gandhi, India's "little Father" (Bapu), had been assassinated by a Hindu Brahman who viewed the "Great Soul" (Mahatma) he murdered as a "Muslim-lover" determined to help Pakistan's army wrest Kashmir from India. It was my introduction to the complexity of